daughters, Christine and Mary, asked us to dance. We were embarrassed and said we could not dance. Mr Smith said, ‘No problem, our girls will teach you.’

This left us with no option but to accept. We nudged each other, whispering ‘you first,’ ‘no, you first,’ awkward at the idea of touching the girls. Boldly, the two sisters came up to us, took our hands and led us to the floor. The gramophone started to play and to the beat of the music, Christine instructed me to ‘put your right foot here and say “one”, put your left foot there and say “two”, one, two, one two…’ And so with my left hand resting on her hand and my right arm around her waist, we danced the foxtrot. Gradually my shyness vanished and I began to enjoy myself.

That night when we returned to the Village, Mohinder Singh and I discussed our evening in great detail. We had a good laugh about our ‘second dinner’, and I teased him, saying, ‘*Tenu ta angrezi andhi hai* (you claim to know English), so why didn’t you say that we had eaten?’

We were both horrified by the parents’ laxity, allowing their daughters to dance so closely with strange men. Such a thing would never ever happen in India. As the days went by, we shed our inhibitions and decided to join in the fun. We invited the girls to the Village and took them to the ballroom. But once there, we did not dare dance with them, so conscious were we by the censure we saw in our fellow Indians’ eyes.

We spent five days with the Smith family. They had begun to regard us with affection and even came to see us off at the airport. We promised to keep in touch, but this is not always possible. We were geographically too far apart, and culturally too different.

Our flight back was uneventful. By now, we had grown accustomed to flying and did not panic as we had before. I was returning home with no trophies or medals, just my resolve to be a world champion. From now on, this became my sole purpose in life.